

Jargon Buster

Root Mean Square (RMS): The sustained power in watts that an amplifier can output at any given time.
Peak Music Power Output (PMPO): The maximum power that an amplifier can output over a short period of time.
Frequency Response: The range of frequencies that the device is set to operate within.

Dolby Digital 5.1 (Dolby AC-3): Developed by Dolby, this system has five discrete sound channels in addition to Low Frequency Effects (LFE) that are directed to the subwoofer.

Dolby Pro Logic: An older standard, this packs in information for a centre and surround channel in the regular stereo channel. Essentially, there are no discrete left and right channels for the rear or surround speakers.

Dolby Pro Logic II: Audio encoded with Pro Logic II carries five channels of sound in a traditional two-channel stereo audio signal, which is then decoded back to five speakers using a Dolby Surround Pro Logic II decoder. This technology can be used on any console that does not support Dolby Digital 5.1. The advantages of using it in

game applications include minimal latency, full frequency range, compatibility with existing cables, and backwards compatibility with mono, stereo and legacy Dolby Surround Pro Logic equipment.

DTS: Short for Digital Theatre Systems, this is a standard invented by Steven Spielberg, and made its debut in *Jurassic Park*. It uses a sampling frequency of 96 KHz with 24 bits allocated to each of the six channels. Collector's edition DVD movies normally feature two soundtracks featuring both Dolby 5.1, and DTS.

Dolby Digital EX and DTS ES: These are comparatively new standards that add an additional channel—the rear centre channel—and is implemented in 6.1 speakers. Both standards implement the rear channel in a similar way. For Dolby Digital EX, a special Dolby Pro Logic decoder is added to the surround channels, creating a rear centre channel. This decoding method first came to light with the theatrical release of *Star Wars Episode 1*. For DTS ES, an additional rear centre channel is supplemented to the two surround channels.

Dolby Pro Logic IIx: This is a spanking-new technology developed by Dolby

Laboratories and is the first and only technology to process native stereo or 5.1 signals into 6.1 or 7.1 channel output. Different modes such as Movie, Music and Game are available with this technology, with the Music mode featuring additional user controls such as Dolby centre width, Dolby panorama, and Dolby dimension.

THX: This is an abbreviation for 'Tomlinson Holman's eXperiment'. It's not a surround sound standard, but a seal of approval that is granted to audio equipment and theatres that meet its standards. This standard is further divided into THX Select (for installations up to 2000 cubic feet) and THX Ultra (for between 2000 and 3000 cubic feet).

S/PDIF: Sony/Philips Digital Interface; a standard audio file transfer format. Developed jointly by Sony and Philips corporations, S/PDIF allows the transfer of digital audio signals from one device to another without having to be converted first to an analogue format. Maintaining the viability of a digital signal prevents the quality of the signal from degrading when it is converted to analogue.

emperor was the Bose set—you really need to hear them to believe it. The speakers are downright tiny, but the depth and punch of the bass simply blew us away! No matter what file or what frequency we threw at it, the speakers just stood there smugly and played it with absolute perfection! There wasn't even a hint of distortion at even the highest volumes, a feat that even our high-end 5.1 systems could not manage.

The Harman/Kardon (H/K) set did the worst in these tests, and due to their peculiar design, the bass started sounding a bit raspy if we increased the volume beyond 50 per cent. The only other speaker that did commendably well here was the Creative Megaworks THX. It could produce clean distortion-free bass at nearly 80 per cent of the volume level.

We then ran our *Half-Life 2* game test and yet again, the Bose came out tops with absolutely unbelievable clarity. We could hear every bombshell exploding, and each bullet being fired—but what really set this speaker system apart was another unmatched feat: despite all the chaos that was happen-

ing, we could distinctly hear everything that was being spoken in the game. Each and every syllable!

The JBL and H/K tied for second spot, and the Creative did rather badly—we heard a lot of in-game distortion, and most dialogues were lost. As expected,



Bose Companion 3 (2.1)

the Bose beat the rest comfortably in the movie test, and *The Fast and the Furious* came alive with the car chases, gun shots and what not!

This time, the JBL marginally edged out the others for second

spot, with the Creative third and the H/K a distant fourth.

We couldn't wait to get to our music tests. We were in for a shock, though—the Bose refused to live up to our expectations, especially in the Audio CD instrumental track. Sure, it was still one of the best speakers, but at high volumes, the sound was getting a bit too tinny for our tastes, and for the first time, we felt the satellites weren't complementing the wonderful subwoofer (Acousti-mass, as Bose calls it).

The Creative and the Bose tied for top spot here, with JBL second and the H/K a distant third.

In the vocals test, however, both Hindi and English, using the audio CD, MP3s or the DVD, the clarity of the Bose was unmatched, and it decimated the opposition with ease. JBL came in second and Creative third, while the H/K brought up the rear.

And The Winner Is...

This was quite simply a fight for second place. The Bose was the outright winner, with the JBL Creature II coming in second.

If you are a performance junkie or an audiophile, and if money is no object, you can't do any better than the Bose.